

Perspectives | The Architecture of Survival

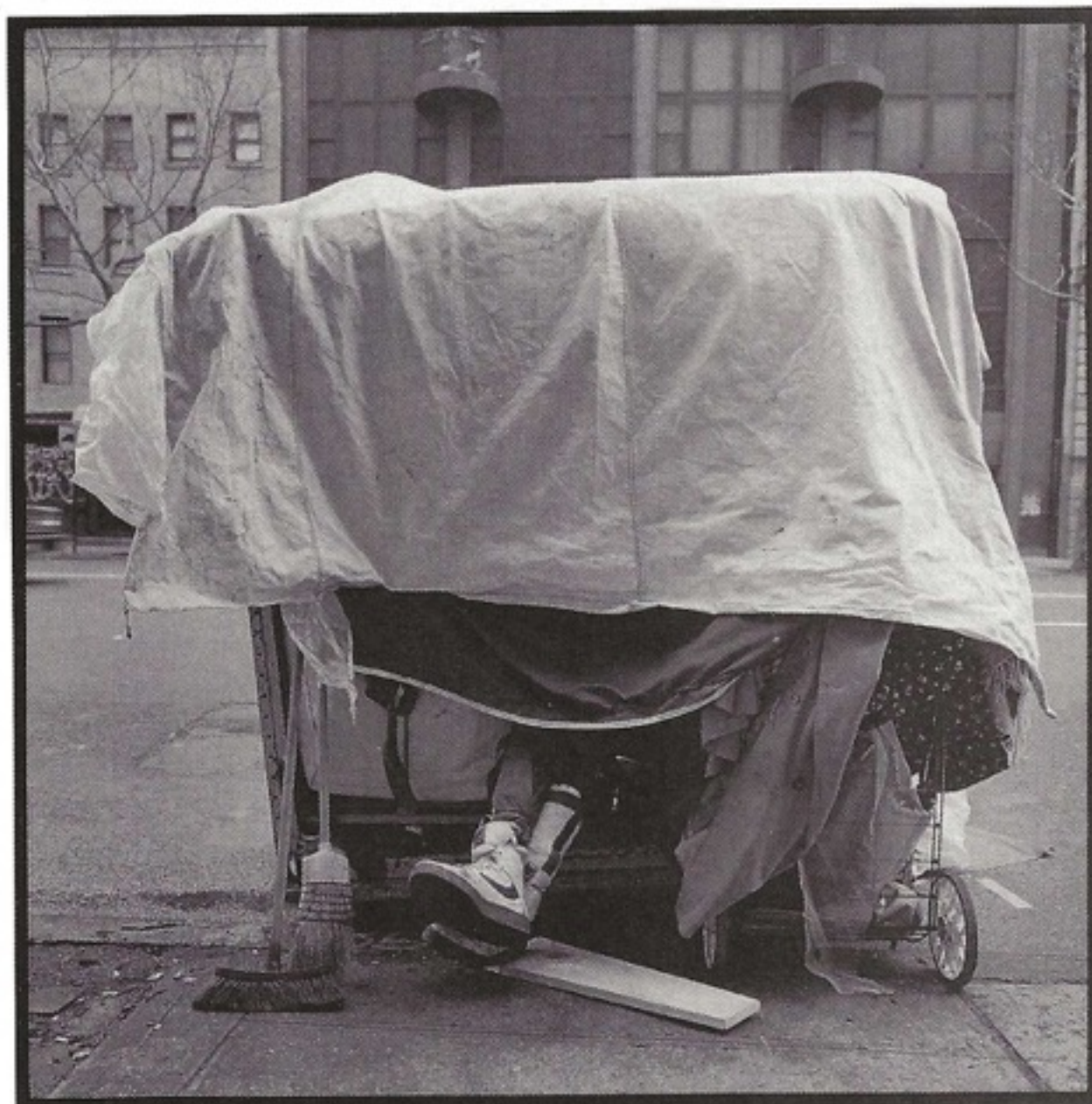
Photographer **Margaret Morton** chronicles the tenacious architecture of Manhattan's homeless.

The makeshift dwellings that the dispossessed of New York construct for themselves go far beyond the need for mere shelter. Since 1989, I have photographed these dwellings in vacant lots and public parks, under bridges and highway ramps. I was concerned that an important record of the homeless crisis would be lost as the dwellings were periodically demolished.

Sometimes reminiscent of the 1930s Hoovervilles in their semipermanence and density, the structures created in these "settlements" have ranged from over 100 dwellings in Tompkins Square Park, which became a national symbol for the plight of the homeless, to a decorated crate hidden inside the entrance to an abandoned tunnel. One of the environments has existed underground for over 19 years; another survived along the street for only a few hours. The makeshift homes, primarily created from consumer detritus reconstituted as building materials, give evidence of the profound need to adorn, collect, and create — to give personal meaning to a private space — even in the most desperate of circumstances.

Many of the homeless people state that they prefer building their own houses to staying in the city's shelter system. Although makeshift plastic tents and plywood shanties are certainly not acceptable housing alternatives, it is my hope that an analysis of the particulars that transform a cardboard box into a home will provide useful insights for the development of more appropriate solutions. **Margaret Morton** ■

*The author, a professor at The Cooper Union School of Art, is coauthor with Diana Balmori of *Transitory Gardens, Uprooted Lives* (Yale University Press, fall release).*





"I built this house in one day and then I kind of reinforced it a little bit. Made sure it doesn't leak. The location is not soundproof so you can hear the birds tweetin' and the ducks quackin'." Thomas Davis

Curtis Cuffie's mobile home (top left) has been photographed in many locations throughout the Lower East Side. Yi Poi Lee's house (bottom left), Chinatown, February 1991. Handwritten messages proclaim: "Mr. Lee the Great Inventor." "You won't find one nail ... holding that place together," says a neighbor. "It's held together with knots." Lee died when an arsonist set fire to his house on May 29, 1992. Above, Thomas Davis' house, East River, February 1993.

"When I came here, I started like a poor person. Now I feel better. I built this house myself. I figure this is my breakthrough to stay here, but sooner or later they're going to chop the houses down. Will they put something here for the people working hard? They suffered making the houses here, you know."

Hector Amezcua

"I'm no architect. God is the architect. He is the best architect in town. When I took over there was nothing, only this room. I had so many leaks and the ceiling was too low. I had to push it up two inches. Then I got tired; I got sick. I had to stop everything. The kitchen is still unfinished, I have to finish the kitchen soon as the weather gets a little warmer - if I am still alive." **Pepe Otero**

The quotes are excerpted from Morton's forthcoming book, The Architecture of Despair. Her photographs are on view at the Lowinsky Gallery in New York through September 4.





Facing page, Hector Amezcuita's house, Bushville, Lower East Side, June (top) and November 1991 (bottom). Main path through Bushville, (top), March 1993. Pepe Otero's house, Bushville; under construction, September 1991 (above center); expanded, with fence constructed from plastic bread trays, February 1992, (above right); interior, October 1992, (above left).